

"I CAN'T BE MUSHARRAF"

DUKE STREET IN LONDON IS A LONG way from the Pakistan prime minister's official residence in Islamabad but the three-room apartment, just off tony Oxford Street, in the heart of the British capital has all the trappings of being home to a man who considers himself a premier-in-exile. The flag of Pakistan flutters on the table in the office room where Nawaz Sharif holds court. There is an unending stream of visitors who are attended to by an army of officials, most of whom served Sharif during his two stints as the head of the government until he was deposed by his handpicked army chief General Pervez Musharraf in a coup in 1999. Last week, he spoke with INDIA TODAY Group Editor PRABHU CHAWLA for Aaj Tak and Headlines Today on his plans and Pakistan's future. Excerpts.

Q. You have been in London for a long time now and seem to be enjoying it here.

A. I miss Islamabad, I miss Pakistan, but London is not a bad place either.

Q. So are you plotting Musharraf's ouster from here?

A. I'm struggling to restore democracy and the rule of law in Pakistan, to restore the Constitution to its position as on October 12, 1999 when a military coup toppled my government.

Q. But nobody supported you when you were ousted. How do you expect people to support you now?

A. I think the nation was in a state of shock at that time. They never thought this could happen to a prime minister, who had a two-third majority.

Q. Musharraf has now survived nearly eight years.

A. I won't call it survival. He's a man whose foundation is wrong, who came



to power at gunpoint, who subverted the Constitution.

Q. What do you think is the future of General Musharraf?

A. What can be the future of a man who doesn't have a proper past? A man who doesn't believe in the rule of law

and in the Constitution; who goes back on the oath he took as an army officer.

Q. But he is the darling of the West.

A. He's not a darling of the West. He is hoodwinking them. He's giving them an impression of being a friend but back home he's doing exactly the opposite. He was responsible for extremist parties gaining power, for sidelining liberal parties like ours and creating a vacuum which was then filled up by the extremist forces.

Q. He attacked the Lal Masjid to prove to the West that he's fighting

"What can be the future of a man who doesn't have a past? A man who doesn't believe in the rule of law, who doesn't believe in the Constitution and the oath he took."